

Figure 1.6 *Chihil Dukhtaran* minar*, topmost epigraphic bands. © Photograph Alka Patel 2011.*

architectural culture of Khurasan. Beyond such waystations, Saljuq political power culminated at the major urban areas along principal routes of travel, so that regional nodes such as Tus-Nishapur and Herat became centers of their own radii of political and architectural–cultural dissemination (cf. Chapter 4).

As discussed in greater detail in Chapter 2, with Saljuq inroads into the Balkh and Sistan regions as early as the mid-eleventh century,[43] the above-mentioned "Saljuq-patronized" architectural culture also found manifestations in Afghanistan. The *minar* of Daulatabad, south of Balkh (Figure 2.19), for example, subscribed to the cylindrical profile of western Saljuq-period *minar*s, but the Daulatabad proportions conveyed a drum-like impression, rather than a "pencil-thin" one. Moreover, the epigraphic program was monumentalized on the shaft, proclaiming its patronage by the Saljuq *vazir* Abu Ja'far Muhammad ibn 'Ali (d. AH 515/1118 CE), the date of construction (AH 502/1108–1109 CE), and even the stucco worker and carpenter.[44] The general observations regarding pro-